recommended the young officer for the nation's highest award. The government may have failed to recognize these heroic men, but for the rest of his career in the army, Behl for one was known by the sobriquet 'Tiger'.

ZIMITHANG

As we have seen, GOC 4 Division, Major General Niranjan Prasad, was the officer on the other end of the heated conversation with Brigadier John Dalvi on 19 October. Despite all the signs of an imminent Chinese attack, Prasad had doggedly insisted that a Company of 1/9 GR should move to Bridge 5 the next morning even though he agreed with Dalvi that the move would serve no tactical purpose and would further stretch his supply lines. Prasad kept falling back on the fact that he had 'orders from above', finally ending the conversation almost in tears.

Division HQ received the first report of the Chinese assault on Khenzemane within minutes of the attack. Shortly after, the barrage on the Rajput and Gorkha positions began. Brigade HQ by then had lost contact with 2 Rajput but was in communication with 1/9 GR, 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers. From all the records available, it seemed everyone was talking to each other, describing the unfolding Chinese attacks. Shortly before 8 a.m., Dalvi spoke to Prasad and reported that the situation in Rongla was untenable and that Brigade HQ was going to fall back on Hathung-la. Dalvi suggested to his GOC that it might be prudent for both 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers to also head for Hathung-la.

No such orders were issued to either of the two battalions at that stage. Obviously, despite the barrage of information that had been pouring in, either the GOC was deluding himself or he was in a state of denial. Had he ordered 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers to withdraw after speaking to Dalvi, both these fine units would have had at least a three to four hour head start over the Chinese in the race to occupy Hathung-la. Instead the GOC decided to fly to Tsangdhar in the single engine Bell 47G-2 helicopter. At the very last minute, there was a change of plan. Prasad would later write: 'I decided to go with him [Squadron Leader Vinod Sehgal], not only to keep an eye on the battle while 7 Brigade HQ was on the move, but because I was keen to supervise the Tsangle withdrawal… I called out to Vinod Sehgal to get his helicopter ready, collected [Major] Ram Singh and set out for the helipad. When emplaning, however, Sehgal raised an objection about the load. While he had no objection to carrying an extra passenger